Cheat Engine 7.5 source audit

Reviewed October 11, 2026.

Source references below are relative to the reviewed checkout.

The reviewed source contains advertising support, optional online services, and an April Fools feature that executes a server response as Lua. No evidence of covert credential theft, general telemetry, unrelated background uploads, bundled-offer installation, or Windows logon and scheduled-task persistence was found in the reviewed code. Building the application from source bypasses the installer while retaining these application features.

Findings

Embedded advertisements. Cheat Engine\cesupport.pas:157-203 implements an ad window using http://www.cheatengine.org/ceads.php or a URL supplied by the calling script. Requests include the window dimensions, executable filename without its extension, an ad counter, and optional script-supplied parameters. Ads can refresh after 120 seconds while the ad window is visible and Cheat Engine is in the foreground. The browser uses Internet Explorer automation (cesupport.pas:223-253).

The Lua function supportCheatEngine activates the ad window (Cheat Engine\LuaHandler.pas:5357-5415,16584). The trainer generator also supports advertisements. Its checkbox, "Don't support Cheat Engine (or yourself)," is checked by default, disabling ads. Unchecking it opens an ad preview and adds the ad function call to the generated trainer (trainergenerator.lfm:276-289; trainergenerator.pas:1294-1300,1868-1905). No activation was found during ordinary startup or in the supplied autorun scripts. Tables and scripts can call the function.

April Fools feature and remote Lua execution. On April 1 each year, the Windows application enables Cheat-e-coins (Cheat Engine\MainUnit.pas:8384-8399). Clicking a purchase button requests https://cheatengine.org/microtransaction.php?action=buy&amount=..., then passes the response to luaL_loadstring and lua_pcall. This executes server-provided Lua inside Cheat Engine without a separate script permission prompt (frmMicrotransactionsUnit.pas:68-90). The execution occurs after the button click; its behavior depends on the server response. No local payment SDK or card and billing fields were found in this feature. The remote response was not inspected. Coin usage is stored in the local Used Coins preference (cheatecoins.pas:393-397).

CE Share network access. The startup script reads bin\autorun\ceshare\server.txt. If the file is absent, setup downloads https://cheatengine.org/cesharelist.txt before asking the user to select a provider (Cheat Engine\bin\autorun\ceshare.lua:128-212). Opening CE Share settings can also download that list (ceshare.lua:237-242). When a provider is configured, startup downloads its process catalogue if the local copy is missing or older than an hour (ceshare.lua:36-47,467-469; ceshare\ceshare_processlistextention.lua:20-73,330). The catalogue is matched against running processes locally.

Cheat queries send the selected process's executable name and, when configured, a secondary identifier. Opening a process from the CE Share tab can trigger a query when the current table, code list, and comments are empty (ceshare_processlistextention.lua:312-325; ceshare_querycheats.lua:12-36). Publishing uploads table contents and metadata. Login sends credentials to the configured provider (ceshare_publish.lua:66-116; ceshare_account.lua:2-13). Provider URLs can use HTTP, which transmits login credentials without transport encryption (Cheat Engine\LuaInternet.pas:208-252).

Providers can supply Lua to compute a secondary identifier. Cheat Engine displays the code and asks the user to allow or cancel execution. Approved code is saved and runs again on later matching queries (Cheat Engine\bin\autorun\ceshare.lua:330-402; ceshare\ceshare_querycheats.lua:17-24). The separate xml.executeLua response handler is commented out (ceshare.lua:405-410).

Update checking. Cheat Engine\bin\autorun\versioncheck.lua:17-18,116-133 downloads version information from https://cheatengine.org/latestversion.txt. Automatic checks require CheckOnLaunch='1'. Checks can also be started from the Help menu. The request contains no explicit user or process identifier. Accepting the update prompt opens the website with ?versioncheck=1.

Promotional links. The About window includes a Patreon link (Cheat Engine\aboutunit.pas:161-173; aboutunit.lfm:454-462). Clicking the main logo asks permission to open the website with a referredby=CE<version> parameter (MainUnit.pas:7109-7119). Both actions require user interaction.

Startup scripts and DLLs. Cheat Engine executes local main.lua or defines.lua, autorun Lua files, and available translation initialization scripts (Cheat Engine\LuaHandler.pas:674-813). The NOAUTORUN command-line option disables scripts in the autorun folder; other Lua initialization remains active (cheatengine.lpr:307,378-402). The source-built executable uses these scripts and precompiled DLLs. The 26 DLLs under Cheat Engine\bin were inventoried; their contents and provenance were not verified.

Local settings at inspection

bin\autorun\ceshare\server.txt was empty, leaving CE Share without a configured provider. HKCU\Software\Cheat Engine\VersionCheck had no CheckOnLaunch value, so automatic update checks were disabled. LuaScriptAction was unset; the table-loading code defaults to running signed table scripts and requesting permission for unsigned scripts (Cheat Engine\OpenSave.pas:771-801).

Audit scope

The audit indexed 1,394 Pascal, Lua, C/C++, header, and C# files. Targeted searches were followed by review of callers, execution conditions, and response handlers. Review covered the Windows project entry point, startup scripts, advertisements, network requests, credential access, process launching, registry persistence, service creation, and supporting scripts. Individual lines throughout the entire source tree were not reviewed.

The services in Cheat Engine\dbk32\DBK32functions.pas:3268-3342 are demand-start kernel drivers for Cheat Engine and Ultimap. Remote debugging and distributed pointer scanning correspond to their stated functions. No installer or bundled-offer scripts were found. appveyor.yml:19 downloads and executes an RDP setup script in AppVeyor's build environment; Lazarus builds of cheatengine.lpi do not invoke it. Cheat Engine\feces.pas implements cheat-table signing and signature verification.

The audit made no changes to application source or settings. It did not execute remote Lua, capture runtime network traffic, verify upstream provenance, or establish that the compiled executable exactly matches the reviewed source. Precompiled DLLs and remote services remain outside the verified scope.

The identified removal points are the ad function and trainer integration, the April Fools coin feature and purchase handler, CE Share if unused, and the update-check script if unwanted.